a profound escalation. But when the Iranians showed resilience and the regime displayed no signs of imminent collapse, the Trump administration changed tack again. The White House press team subsequently outlined four major pillars: destroying Iran's missile and drone capabilities; preventing any future nuclear weapons programme; weakening Iran's ability to project power across the region; and ultimately empowering the Iranian people to end the clerical theocracy. Yet many analysts believe that the war does not reflect any coherent master strategy. They caution that the decision may have stemmed from short-term calculations rather than a carefully designed long-term plan. As one expert who has worked extensively in the region put it, "We may be attributing grand strategy to what are actually decisions evolving day by day."

REGIME CHANGE GAMBIT

If the US and Israel expected that the decapitation of Iran's leadership would lead to the rapid dismantling of its theocratic establishment, they were soon disappointed. Iran is no Venezuela or a fragile microstate like Gaza that can be easily overrun. It is a nation of 92 million people, with a deeply entrenched security apparatus. In size, Iran is the 17th largest country in the world, bounded by high mountains and forbidding deserts that historically made it an impregnable fortress for invaders and, given its population, it is difficult to overwhelm.

MANY ANALYSTS SEE NO MASTER STRATEGY TO THE WAR. "WE MAY BE ATTRIBUTING GRAND STRATEGY TO DECISIONS EVOLVING DAILY," SAYS ONE

With around 90 per cent of Iran's population being Shia Muslim, the concept of martyrdom occupies a central symbolic and emotional place in its religious culture. Khamenei, the slain spiritual leader, may have had his detractors, and even some of his associates may have been exasperated by his stubborn streak, but in death he has attained the status of a martyr, revered as an Imam or spiritual figure even more than when he was alive. In Iran, Trump and his cabal are now derisively referred to as 'the Epstein Gang'. "This gang is now seen as the Yazid, the archetype of injustice," says Zaidi, "and Imam Khamenei is now regarded as the Husayn of our time, the archetype of righteous martyrdom."

Removing a leader, even one unpopular at home, does not necessarily collapse the system under him. Anticipating the possibility of his assassination, Khamenei had built several layers of succession not only for his own post but also for key positions in the clerical hierarchy, the armed forces and the IRGC. Immediately after his death, Iran invoked

IMPACT ON INDIA

A TWIN BLOW

Costlier energy imports and a fall in remittances from the millions of Indians working in the Gulf countries could imperil the Indian economy

By M.G. Arun

For India, the escalating conflict in West Asia threatens a double economic blow. Disruptions in oil and gas supplies could drive up energy costs, while the livelihoods of millions of Indian migrants in the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries—the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Bahrain, Qatar and Kuwait—may also come under strain, squeezing a key source of remittances.

India is the world's third-largest consumer of oil but imports nearly 89 per cent of its crude requirements. The economy still runs heavily on fossil fuels, consuming more than five million barrels per day—behind China's 15.2 million and the United States' 20 million.

Oil prices, which were until recently in the $65–70 (Rs 6,000–6,450) per barrel range, have been rising following US and Israeli strikes on Iran. Global Brent crude climbed to about $83.9 (Rs 7,700) a barrel on March 5 and analysts expect it to cross $90 (Rs 8,300) if the conflict intensifies. That's largely because Iran's retaliatory strikes targeted not only US military facilities in GCC countries but also energy infrastructure in the region. Qatar, the world's largest producer of liquefied natural gas (LNG), halted its production from March 3 amid the escalating hostilities.

As prices rise, Union petroleum minister Hardeep Singh Puri has said the Centre will "ensure availability and affordability of major petroleum products in the country". Yet doing so will not be easy. India currently has petroleum reserves sufficient for about 74 days—

CRUDE SHOCK

Oil prices, which were until recently in the $65–70 (Rs 6,000–6,450) per barrel range, have been rising following US and Israeli strikes on Iran

